

A

Verbs of concession

Concession means accepting one part of an idea or fact, but putting another, more important argument or fact against it.

It can be expressed with a conjunction, e.g. **Although** *they were poor, they were independent*, or an adverb, e.g. *He is a bit stupid. He's very kind, nevertheless*, or through verbs like those in the table below.

example	paraphrase and comments
I acknowledge/accept that he has worked hard but it isn't enough.	I agree but ... (accept is less formal than acknowledge)
I admit I was wrong, but I still think we were right to doubt her.	I accept I'm guilty of what I'm accused of.
I concede that you are right about the goal, but not the method.	You have won this point in our argument. (rather formal, used in debates/arguments)

B

Adverbs and other phrases showing contrast

These examples are fairly informal:

OK, you're sorry. **That's all well and good** / **That's all very well**, but how are you going to pay us back?

You shouldn't seem so surprised. **After all**, I did warn you.

It's all very well saying you love dogs, but who will take it for walks if we *do* get one?

He *is* boring, and he *is* rather cold and unfriendly, but, **for all that**, he *is* your uncle and we should invite him.

These examples are more formal:

Admittedly, she put a lot of effort in, but it was all wasted.

I thought she didn't like me. In fact, **the reverse was true**.

In Europe they use metric measurements. **In contrast**, the USA still uses many non-metric measurements.

It's not actually raining now. **On the other hand**, it may rain later, so take the umbrella.



We're not almost there at all.
Quite the opposite: we've got five miles to go yet.

C

Collocating phrases for contrast

When it comes to politics, Jamie and Isla are **poles apart**.

There's a **world of difference** between being a friend and a lover.

There's a **great divide** between city residents and people who live in the country.

A **yawning gap** divides the rich and poor in many countries.

There's a **huge discrepancy** between his ideals and his actions.

Language help

On the other hand means 'that is true *and* this is also true if we look at it from a different viewpoint', e.g. *Life in the country is nice and quiet. On the other hand, you have to go a long way to get to the shops.* **On the contrary** is a rather formal expression which means 'that is *not* true; the opposite is true', e.g. A: *You must be pleased with your exam results.* B: *On the contrary, I thought they would be much better.*

Exercises

64.1 Rewrite these sentences using the most likely verb from A opposite (there is usually more than one possibility).

- 1 I know that you weren't solely to blame, but you must take some responsibility.
I accept that you weren't solely to blame but you must take some responsibility.
- 2 OK, OK, I was wrong, you were right; he is a nice guy.
- 3 The company is prepared to accept that you have suffered some delay, but we do not accept liability.
- 4 She didn't deny that we had done all we could, but she was still not content.

64.2 Complete the sentences with phrases from B opposite.

1 OK, you've cleaned the kitchen;
that's all very well , but what
about the dining room?

2 No need to panic.
..... , it
doesn't start till six.

3 She's bossy and sly, but
..... ,
she is a friend.

4 saying
you'll pay me back soon;
when is what I want to know!

5 I know you've been very busy
preparing for the school concert.
..... , but you still
mustn't neglect your homework.

64.3 Use the word in brackets in an appropriate collocation to make comments on these statements.

- 1 Some people believe in nuclear weapons, some in world disarmament. (divide)
There's a great divide between those who believe in nuclear weapons, and those who believe in world disarmament.
- 2 She says one thing. She does quite the opposite. (discrepancy)
- 3 Toby believes in saving as much as possible. Catalina prefers to spend all the money they earn. (poles)
- 4 Being a student's one thing; being a teacher's quite another. (world)
- 5 People in the north of the country have a totally different standard of living from those in the south.
(gap)

64.4 Write a sentence before each of these sentences.

- 1 *I expected Lydia to be tall and dark.* The reverse was true; she was short, with fair hair.
- 2 On the other hand, it does have a big garden, so I think we should rent it.
- 3 On the contrary, the number of cars on the road is increasing yearly.
- 4 In contrast, in Britain you drive on the left.
- 5 Quite the opposite; I feel quite full. I had a huge breakfast.

64.5 Choose between *on the other hand* and *on the contrary* and explain what the speaker means.

- 1 I'm not worried; *on the contrary* , I feel quite calm. *It's not true that I'm worried.*
- 2 It's expensive, but , we do need it.
- 3 In some ways I'd like to change my job, but , I'd miss all my colleagues.
- 4 I don't think he's lazy; , he puts in a great deal of effort.
- 5 She doesn't speak Japanese well; , she only knows a couple of phrases.
- 6 This hotel looks very attractive; , it's more expensive than the first one we looked at.